

National Gallery - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

The National Gallery: A Collection Built Backwards

The National Gallery, founded in 1824, is unusual among great European museums in that it wasn't built from a royal collection — Britain's Parliament simply started buying, beginning with thirty-eight pictures from the banker John Julius Angerstein. The result is a collection curated by argument rather than inherited by accident, and it shows: at around two thousand three hundred paintings it's a fraction of the Louvre's size, but the hit rate per room is arguably the best in the world — a deliberate survey of Western European painting from Giotto to Cézanne with astonishingly few gaps. The building's position is political: on Trafalgar Square, at the meeting point of wealthy Westminster and the poorer East End, chosen explicitly so all classes could reach it, and free from the start — a principle Britain's national museums retain. During the Second World War the entire collection was evacuated to a slate mine in Wales, and the gallery ran famous lunchtime concerts by Myra Hess in the empty rooms; from 1942, one masterpiece a month was brought back and displayed alone, the "Picture of the Month," as a morale gesture — queues formed through the Blitz. You have an hour or so with six people, so resist completism. The Sainsbury Wing you're entering through holds the early Renaissance; three or four rooms deeply beat thirty at a jog.

Tell Me More: How the Pictures Got Here — and Nearly Didn't

A few acquisition stories put flesh on the collection. The gallery's early decades were a comedy of parliamentary stinginess and connoisseur intrigue: the director Charles Eastlake toured Italy annually with his formidable wife Elizabeth, buying early Renaissance pictures then deeply unfashionable — the Piero della Francesca and Botticellis acquired for relative pennies are now beyond price. Whistlejacket arrived only in 1997, bought for eleven million pounds from the family that commissioned it, having hung in the same house for two hundred thirty years. The Rokeby Venus was slashed seven times in 1914 by the suffragette Mary Richardson, protesting Emmeline Pankhurst's arrest — she said she attacked the most beautiful woman in mythological history because the government was destroying the most beautiful character in modern history; the repairs are nearly invisible, and the episode permanently changed gallery security. The wartime evacuation to the Manod slate quarry in Wales required blasting the mine entrance larger to admit the biggest canvases, and climate control installed in the mountain taught the gallery more about conservation conditions than a century of London coal smoke had; when the "Picture of the Month" scheme brought single works back to the Blitz-era public, the first requested was Titian. And one omission is deliberate: British art mostly lives at Tate, by an 1897 division of labor — so the Turners and Constables here are the overlap the gallery refused to give up.

Tell Me More: The Building and Its Battles

The gallery you're standing in is as contested as its contents. The main building, William Wilkins's neoclassical front along Trafalgar Square, opened in 1838 and was mocked almost at once, critics deriding its meagre dome and flanking turrets as a cruet stand, or a set of pepperpots, atop a portico that had been cannibalised from a demolished aristocratic mansion nearby. The awkward proportions came partly

from a stingy budget and the need to share the site with the Royal Academy, which lodged here until it decamped to Piccadilly in 1868.

The most modern quarrel concerns the Sainsbury Wing, the very rooms you entered through, which house the early Renaissance. When a sleek high-tech design was first proposed for the extension in 1984, the then Prince of Wales publicly denounced it as a monstrous carbuncle on the face of a much-loved and elegant friend, a single phrase that killed the scheme and reshaped British architecture debates for a generation. The wing that eventually opened in 1991, by the American postmodernists Robert Venturi and Denise Scott Brown, quotes Wilkins's columns in a witty, deliberately ambiguous way that still divides opinion.

The gallery marked its two hundredth birthday in 2024, and the Sainsbury Wing reopened in 2025 after a major reworking of its entrance and public spaces, part of a long campaign to make a building that began life as a cramped compromise finally feel like the national institution it is. Look up as you pass through: almost every stone here was fought over.

Tell Me More: How the Impressionists Arrived

The Impressionist and Post-Impressionist rooms you're heading for exist largely because of two men, one who died in a shipwreck and one who made a fortune in fabric. In the gallery's founding vision, modern French painting had no place at all; it arrived late, and by luck and stubbornness.

Hugh Lane, an Irish dealer and collector, left a group of superb Impressionist pictures in a will whose crucial codicil, leaving them to Dublin, he signed but never had witnessed before he drowned on the *Lusitania*, torpedoed off Ireland in 1915. The result was a bitter tug of war between London and Dublin that lasted decades and was only settled by an agreement to share the pictures, rotating them between the two cities, an arrangement still running today. Some of the finest French works here are Lane's.

The other benefactor was Samuel Courtauld, heir to a textile firm, who in 1923 endowed a fund of fifty thousand pounds specifically to buy modern French painting for the nation, at a moment when the British establishment still regarded Cézanne and Seurat as barely respectable. That fund bought Seurat's monumental *Bathers at Asnières*, works by Van Gogh, Cézanne and Renoir, and effectively created the collection you're about to walk through. So when you reach those glowing rooms, remember they were nobody's inheritance. They were argued in, bequeathed by a drowned man, and purchased by a manufacturer who thought the future was worth the gamble.

Holbein and Van Eyck: Painting as Puzzle

Two northern masterpieces here reward slow looking. Holbein's *Ambassadors*, 1533, shows Jean de Dinteville and Georges de Selve, French envoys to Henry the Eighth's court in the exact year of the break with Rome — and the still life between them is a coded inventory of a world coming apart: a lute with a broken string, a Lutheran hymnbook lying open, scientific instruments set to dates scholars still argue about. The anamorphic skull smeared across the foreground resolves only from a point high on the right — the traditional theory being the painting hung on a staircase, so the skull leapt out at you in passing. It is *memento mori* as ambush. Van Eyck's *Arnolfini Portrait* of 1434 is possibly the most argued-about painting in the building: long read as a wedding, complete with the theory that the picture itself is the legal witness — the convex mirror reflects two figures entering the room, and above it Van Eyck signed, in notarial script, “Johannes de eyck fuit hic,” Jan van Eyck was here. Modern scholarship has picked the marriage-certificate theory apart without settling on a replacement, which is the fun of it. Technically it's a landmark of the oil medium Van Eyck perfected: the mirror's ten miniature roundels of the Passion are each smaller than a fingernail.

Tell Me More: Reading the Objects

Deeper into both pictures' furniture. The *Ambassadors*' upper shelf holds instruments of the heavens — celestial globe, sundials, quadrants; the lower shelf, instruments of Earth — terrestrial globe, arithmetic book, lute, hymnal: a two-story diagram of the cosmos, with humanity's discords on the ground floor. The arithmetic book is open to a page beginning with division; the Lutheran hymnbook lies in a Catholic diplomat's portrait; the cylindrical dial has been read as showing a date in 1533 — scholars have proposed Good Friday — and the terrestrial globe pointedly marks Dinteville's home château. The skull's function may have been positional: hung on a staircase, correct anamorphic viewing would occur as you climbed past — vanity face-on, death in passing. Some scholars add that from the skull's viewpoint the rest of the painting blurs: you may see the world or see death clearly, never both. For the *Arnolfini*, the modern scholarship is deliciously unsettled: the National Gallery's own catalogue now doubts the wedding reading; candidates for the couple have shifted; the woman is probably not pregnant — she gathers a fashionable volume of skirt — and one dark theory reads it as a memorial portrait of a wife already dead, noting the single burning candle on his side, the burnt-out stub on hers. Van Eyck's mirror frame contains ten Passion roundels, alive on his side, death-and-resurrection on hers. It may be the most over-interpreted painting alive — and it earns every theory.

Tell Me More: Holbein at a Dangerous Court

Hans Holbein the Younger painted *The Ambassadors* while working the most perilous freelance job in Europe: portraitist to the court of Henry the Eighth. Born in Augsburg, trained in the German and Swiss tradition, he came to England first in the late 1520s carrying a recommendation from the humanist Erasmus, whose portrait he had painted, and returned in 1532 as the Reformation was tearing the country from Rome. He became the king's painter, and his images are, quite literally, how we picture the Tudor world, the swaggering Henry, the merchants and courtiers, the doomed queens.

The peril was real. In 1539 Holbein was sent to paint Anne of Cleves, a German princess Henry was considering as his fourth wife. Holbein's portrait, still much admired, was flattering enough that the king agreed to the marriage sight unseen, then recoiled when he met her in the flesh, complaining bitterly and annulling the union within months. The matchmaker who arranged it, Thomas Cromwell, lost his head over the fiasco. Holbein survived, his reputation dented but his neck intact.

Look at the sheer descriptive intensity of his surfaces, the millefleurs pattern of the carpet, the pinpoint reflections in the instruments, the fur and velvet you can almost feel. This was painting as evidence, a north-European faith that truth lives in the accumulated detail of the visible world. Holbein worked, as his contemporaries did, on prepared oak panel rather than canvas, building translucent layers over a meticulous underdrawing. He died in London, probably of plague, in 1543, still in the king's service.

Tell Me More: Van Eyck and the Oil Revolution

For centuries a myth persisted, repeated by the Italian biographer Vasari, that Jan van Eyck invented oil painting. He didn't; painters had used oil binders before him. But the exaggeration honours a real truth: nobody had ever handled the medium as he did, and the Arnolfini Portrait is its manifesto. Working in Bruges in the 1430s, in the wealthy, cosmopolitan orbit of the Dukes of Burgundy, Van Eyck exploited oil's slow drying and transparency to build colour in thin glazes, layer upon layer, achieving a depth and luminosity that tempera on panel simply could not reach.

The effect is a near-hallucinatory realism: individual bristles in the little dog's coat, the brass of the chandelier catching light, the world outside implied in the window. Ultramarine, ground from lapis lazuli hauled overland from Afghanistan and worth more than gold, glows in the woman's gown. Every surface reports a different texture, and the convex mirror on the back wall bends the whole room, including two figures at the threshold, into its silvered curve.

This is the northern Renaissance running on a different engine from the Italian one being invented at the same moment. Where Florentine painters pursued idealised form, mathematical perspective and the antique, the Netherlands pursued the particular, the tactile, the microscopically observed, and reached a comparable grandeur by the opposite road. Van Eyck's technique swept south within a generation, and Italian painters, Antonello da Messina among them, hurried to learn the secrets of the oil medium that the man who signed himself simply as having been here had carried to perfection.

Turner's Temeraire and Van Gogh's Sunflowers

The Fighting Temeraire, 1839, voted the nation's favorite painting in a 2005 BBC poll, is Turner editorializing shamelessly and magnificently. The Temeraire — second ship of the line at Trafalgar, whose crew boarded and took the French Redoubtable minutes after its sharpshooter mortally wounded Nelson — was sold for scrap in 1838 and towed to Rotherhithe. Turner reengineers the facts: the tow happened over two days, mostly unrigged, masts already sold off; he restores her masts, paints her spectral white and gold, invents the elegiac sunset, and puts the sun setting in the east if you check the geography. He knew exactly what he was doing — “my darling,” he called it, refusing all offers and leaving it to the nation. It's the nineteenth century's anxiety about progress in one image: filthy, vigorous steam hauling beautiful, obsolete sail. Van Gogh's Sunflowers, 1888, is one of seven versions, painted in Arles in a heat of optimism as he prepared the Yellow House for Gauguin's arrival — sunflowers as emblems of friendship and the south, executed in the new chrome yellows industrial chemistry had just made available, some of which are slowly darkening, so conservators now monitor the painting's chemistry like a patient. The two pictures make a neat pairing: both are about brightness produced by the industrial age, and both painters poured private feeling into ostensibly simple subjects.

Tell Me More: Bequests, Bonfires and Chemistry

Turner's bequest is a saga of its own: he left his finished pictures to the nation on condition that two hang forever beside two Claudes — the French master he spent a career dueling — and the gallery honors it to this day in Room 15: Turner and Claude, permanently side by side, the challenge inscribed in the hanging. The rest of the bequest, contested by relatives for years, came to some three hundred oils and nineteen thousand works on paper, including sketchbooks whose private erotica John Ruskin was long rumored to have burned to protect the great man's reputation — a Victorian legend now largely debunked, the “destroyed” material having turned up, catalogued, in the Tate's vaults. Van Gogh's chemistry, meanwhile, has become a conservation discipline: his beloved chrome yellows — industrial pigments born of the same century as Turner's tugboat — darken under light through a reduction of chromium at the paint surface, so the Sunflowers are studied with synchrotron X-rays and displayed under strict lux limits; the painting you see is very slightly less blazing than the one Gauguin saw in the Yellow House, and no restorer can safely reverse it. The two artists bracket a theme the gallery quietly teaches: the nineteenth century's new industrial colors and machines gave painters unprecedented means — and both these pictures are, at bottom, about what that new world was doing to the old one.

Tell Me More: Turner, Father of the Impressionists

There's a direct line from Turner's dissolving light to the rooms of Monet and Renoir you're about to enter, and it runs through this very city. In 1870, fleeing the Franco-Prussian War and the Siege of Paris, the young Claude Monet took refuge in London, along with Camille Pissarro. Both spent that grey, foggy winter studying the British masters, and both later acknowledged the shock of Turner, whose late canvases had already dissolved solid form into pure atmosphere, steam, spray, blinding sun, decades before anyone spoke of Impressionism.

Turner had spent his career pushing toward exactly what the Impressionists would make their creed: that the true subject of a painting is not the object but the light and air between the object and the eye. His critics were baffled; the essayist William Hazlitt sniffed that Turner painted pictures of nothing, and very like it. What looked like failure to finish was in fact a radical proposal about what painting is for, and Monet grasped it.

The connection came full circle. Around 1900, a rich and famous Monet returned to London specifically to paint the Thames and the Houses of Parliament wreathed in the city's notorious fog, that dense, coal-smoke air he called wonderful, producing his own shimmering series in open homage to the atmosphere Turner had taught him to see. Those late London canvases hang in Paris, Chicago and Washington rather than here, but the National Gallery holds Monet's earlier, crisper view called *The Thames below Westminster*, painted during that first exile, the first fruit of a lesson learned from a dead Englishman.

Tell Me More: Van Gogh's Chair and the Yellow House

The *Sunflowers* belong to one of the most poignant episodes in art, and the gallery holds its bleak counterpart a short walk away. In 1888 Van Gogh moved to Arles in the south of France, rented the Yellow House, and dreamed of founding a community of painters. The sunflower canvases were painted, in a fever of optimism, to decorate the guest room for the one colleague he persuaded to come, Paul Gauguin.

The experiment curdled fast. The two men, temperamentally opposite, quarrelled ferociously through the autumn, and in December Van Gogh, in a breakdown, severed part of his own ear; Gauguin fled, and the dream of the studio of the south collapsed. Out of that same period comes the painting here titled *Van Gogh's Chair*, a plain rush-seated chair with his pipe and tobacco, which he conceived as a portrait of himself by proxy, paired with a grander, curvier empty chair standing for the absent Gauguin. Two chairs, two men, one rupture.

Van Gogh spent his last eighteen months in and out of an asylum at Saint-Rémy and then at Auvers, near Paris, painting with astonishing speed and intensity, before dying from a gunshot wound in the summer of 1890, aged thirty-seven, still effectively unknown and unsold. His posthumous fame owes much to his sister-in-law Johanna, widow of his devoted brother Theo, who spent decades tirelessly promoting the work and publishing the letters. Stand before the blazing *Sunflowers* and the mute little chair, and you have the whole arc: the ecstatic hope and the wreckage, from the same hand, the same year.

The Impressionist Rooms

These rooms hold the movement that broke painting open. In April 1874, a group of Paris artists exhausted by rejection from the official Salon mounted their own show under a cumbersome cooperative name. A critic, reviewing it in the satirical press, seized on a hazy harbour scene by Monet titled *Impression, Sunrise* and mockingly christened the whole group Impressionists, meaning they offered mere sketches, impressions, rather than finished pictures. The insult stuck, and became a banner.

What united them was an ambition to paint modern life and, above all, light: the fleeting effects of sun, weather and atmosphere, caught with rapid, broken brushwork and unmixed colour, often working outdoors, *en plein air*, made newly practical by paint sold ready in metal tubes. To a public schooled on smooth, dark, high-minded Salon painting, the results looked raw, garish, unfinished, even insolent.

Look for Monet's *Water-Lily Pond*, his *Gare Saint-Lazare* with its steam and iron, and *The Thames below Westminster* from his London winter. Renoir is here twice over, the ravishing *Skiff* and the great crowd scene of *The Umbrellas*. Seek out Pissarro's *Boulevard Montmartre at Night*, a rare nocturne of wet Paris pavements, Degas's dancers and his vertiginous circus acrobat, and Manet's *Music in the Tuileries*, the older provocateur who fathered the movement yet never exhibited with it. Note too Cézanne's monumental *Bathers*, already straining past Impressionism toward something more architectural. Get close to any of these and the surface dissolves into strokes; step back, and the world reassembles in light.

Tell Me More: Why It Looked Like an Outrage

To understand why Impressionism scandalised its first audiences, you have to understand what it defied. Nineteenth-century French painting was ruled by the Salon, the vast state-sponsored exhibition whose jury enforced a hierarchy in which grand historical, religious and mythological subjects sat at the top and a loosely brushed glimpse of ordinary life ranked near the bottom. Success at the Salon made careers; rejection could end them. The Impressionists' sin was double: they painted the wrong subjects, and they painted them the wrong way.

The subjects were resolutely modern and unheroic, railway stations, boulevards, boating parties, suburban riverbanks, dancers backstage, the leisure and labour of contemporary Paris, rather than gods and battles. And the handling looked, to trained eyes, like a first sketch mistaken for a finished work: visible, separate strokes, shadows rendered in colour rather than brown or black, forms defined by patches of light instead of firm contours. Critics complained that the paintings had to be viewed from across the room to make sense at all, which was precisely the point.

The technical enablers mattered. Portable paint in tubes let artists work outdoors, finishing a canvas on the spot in a single charged session before the light shifted. New, brilliant synthetic pigments widened the palette. And a growing awareness of optics encouraged them to place contrasting colours side by side and let the eye do the blending. The group held eight exhibitions between 1874 and 1886, quarrelling and fragmenting as they went, and within a generation the scandal had become the most beloved painting in the Western canon.

Tell Me More: Six Pictures Worth Slowing For

Let the individual canvases repay a closer read. Monet's *Gare Saint-Lazare* of 1877 takes the least poetic subject imaginable, a Paris railway shed, and finds beauty in billowing engine steam diffusing the light beneath a great glass and iron roof, modernity itself as a fit subject for art. His *Thames below Westminster*, painted during his 1870 London exile, already shows the fascination with river fog and

silhouetted architecture that would draw him back thirty years later for the famous Parliament series now dispersed to other museums.

Renoir's *Umbrellas* rewards patient looking because it was painted in two campaigns years apart: the figures on the right retain the soft, feathery Impressionist touch of around 1881, while those on the left, and the umbrellas themselves, show the cooler, firmer, more linear manner of his so-called dry period a few years later, after a chastening study of the old masters. It is a single canvas containing an artist changing his mind.

Pissarro's *Boulevard Montmartre at Night* is one of a whole series he painted from a hotel window as an ageing man, tracking the same stretch of grand boulevard through changing hours and seasons; this rain-slicked nocturne, with its smears of gaslight, is a rarity among Impressionist works. And keep in mind Manet, whose *Music in the Tuileries* was a manifesto of painted modern life a decade before 1874, yet who, ever the ambivalent insider, chose to fight for recognition at the Salon and never once showed with the Impressionists he had inspired.

Pointillism and Seurat

Dominating its wall is one of the gallery's undisputed masterpieces, Georges Seurat's *Bathers at Asnières* of 1884, some two metres by three, a frieze of working men and boys idling by the Seine in an industrial suburb north-west of Paris, factory chimneys smoking faintly across the water. Painted before he had turned twenty-five, it was meant as a grand Salon debut; the jury rejected it, and Seurat showed it instead at the breakaway Salon des Indépendants he helped found.

The picture is the threshold of a new method. Seurat, dissatisfied with Impressionism's spontaneity, wanted to put its instinct for colour on a rigorous, quasi-scientific footing. He built form from countless small, deliberate touches of pure, unmixed pigment, laid side by side so that they fuse not on the palette but in the viewer's eye, a technique variously called pointillism, divisionism, or, in his own preferred term, chromoluminarism. He drew on colour theorists, chiefly Michel-Eugène Chevreul on the law of simultaneous contrast, and the American physicist Ogden Rood on optical mixing, arguing that colour combined by the eye is more luminous than colour muddled on the palette.

Bathers itself is still relatively smoothly brushed; Seurat later reworked passages, dabbing his signature dots into the boy's hat. The fully dotted statement is his *Sunday on La Grande Jatte*, now in Chicago. Note nearby a small Seurat oil study, *The Rainbow*, and remember his method as you look: approach, and the field breaks into confetti; retreat, and it coalesces into still, radiant summer light.

Tell Me More: The Science Behind the Dots

Seurat's dots rest on real nineteenth-century colour science, filtered through his own convictions. The foundational figure was Michel-Eugène Chevreul, a chemist who ran the dye works at the Gobelins tapestry manufactory in Paris and, puzzling over why certain wools looked dull beside others, formulated the law of simultaneous contrast: any colour placed next to another pushes that neighbour toward its own opposite, so a grey looks warmer beside blue, and complementary pairs set side by side intensify each other. His 1839 treatise became scripture for a generation of painters. To this Seurat added the writings of the American physicist Ogden Rood and the critic Charles Blanc, who described how separate specks of colour merge optically at a distance.

From these Seurat drew a working rule: rather than mixing green on the palette, lay dots of blue and yellow side by side and let the eye combine them, yielding, he believed, a purer and more vibrant result. In truth the physics is imperfect, optical blending of pigment dots tends to grey down as much as it glows, and modern eyes often find his surfaces more silvery than incandescent, but the discipline produced an unmistakable, shimmering stillness.

The cost was time. Where a Monet might be seized in a session, a major Seurat was the labour of months of methodical, almost monastic application, dot by dot; the *Grande Jatte* occupied him for two years. He even carried the divided touch onto his painted frames and borders, dabbing complementary dots around the edges so that nothing, right to the margin, interrupted the optical logic of the whole.

Tell Me More: Seurat, Signac and the Neo-Impressionists

Georges Seurat was a paradox: a revolutionary who behaved like a civil servant. Born in 1859 to a comfortable Paris family, academically trained, reserved to the point of secrecy about his private life, he pursued his radical method with the cool method of a scientist rather than the flourish of a bohemian. He and his allies were christened the Neo-Impressionists by the critic Félix Fénéon in 1886, when the *Bathers*'

successor, the *Grande Jatte*, stunned the final Impressionist exhibition, a picture that seemed to freeze the flux of Impressionism into something monumental and eternal.

His chief disciple and friend was Paul Signac, younger, more ebullient, who took up the divided touch with hotter colour and looser mosaic-like strokes, and who, after Seurat's death, became the movement's tireless theorist and promoter. Signac's 1899 book, *From Eugène Delacroix to Neo-Impressionism*, gave the method its enduring name, divisionism, and its manifesto. The influence rippled outward: Van Gogh briefly adopted the dotted touch after meeting the group in Paris, and the young Matisse passed through a divisionist phase that helped detonate the pure colour of Fauvism.

Seurat's own story was cut cruelly short. In the spring of 1891 he fell suddenly ill, probably with a form of diphtheria, and died within days, only thirty-one, his last great canvas unfinished. The *Bathers* here had a wandering life before the Samuel Courtauld Fund secured it for the nation in 1924, one of the boldest purchases of modern art a British institution had yet dared. Stand back from it, and you are looking at the calm before an entire century of colour broke loose.